Modern Cynicism

Rohan Gayen

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Welcome

This is the theory to unify all existing fragmented ideas on human psychology. I've been working on this theory for the last six years, looking at human psychology but from the viewpoint of physics.

I've observed that everything around us that humans have created is ultimately limited by our own creativity. Think about it — in movies, aliens almost always end up looking a lot like us. Even AI systems are built as models of the human brain. If we could truly understand human psychology from first principles, we'd be able to grasp almost anything. When you pick up a new subject, it wouldn't feel completely foreign anymore. You'd connect it easily to your existing mental models and learn much faster.

Human psychology is a huge topic, though. How do we make it something everyone can grasp? It's similar to what happened with mathematics. In the early days, there were no symbols—everything was discussed verbally, so only a few geniuses could really follow it. Now school kids learn math. That democratization came when math was turned into a formal language with symbols. The same shift happened with communication and data after Shannon's 1948 paper, which kicked off the Information Age.

Before that, people built machines and networks mostly based on intuition.

I believe we can do something similar for knowledge itself. I view human behavior through the philosophy of data. At the heart of it, all human behavior can be explained using just three basic data operations:

- Data is stored somewhere,
- Computations happen on that data, and
- Data gets transferred from one storage to another.

Everything else — all the complex layers we see in society are basically abstractions we've built on top of these operations. They're there to help us reduce the energy needed to carry them out.

Once you really get this pattern, you'll start noticing it everywhere. In software engineering, economics, productivity advice, salary negotiations, even military strategies. It turns you into a natural generalist and critical thinker. You learn something once and can apply it across so many areas. And in today's world with AI handling more and more low-level tasks, this mindset becomes especially powerful. It helps us move up the value chain into roles where we direct and manage, while AI takes care of the execution.

On the societal side, this feels like the fastest way for people from poorer backgrounds to catch up. We've all heard the usual advice — read books, work hard, and things will improve. But from my own experience, a lot of that doesn't capture the real picture. The deepest knowledge often comes from lived experience, not from what's written in books. Plus, we've split knowledge into separate subjects, making it hard to connect everything into one coherent way of thinking that actually leads to innovation.

My bigger dream is intellectual equality in society. Imagine a time when the child of a wealthy industrialist and the child of an ordinary farmer have the same level of intellect and can have meaningful discussions on equal footing with scientists or anyone else. There would be no institutional roadblocks standing in the way of social mobility, because upskilling wouldn't depend on gatekeepers. For me, intellect means the ability to think for yourself — whether in academics, family matters, or dealing with tough situations at work. In the language of the theory, it's about executing those three data operations efficiently: using minimal energy, achieving the maximum rewards, and hurting others as little as possible.

The effects of this could be felt worldwide, but they would be especially strong in places like India because of our large population. If we can implement these ideas, the level of innovation could skyrocket, helping India move toward becoming a true superpower on a scale similar to the Industrial Revolution. People talk a lot about AI's impact these days, but I'm focused on unlocking the full potential of human minds. The same principles might even help us build better AI systems here — perhaps by getting the thinking layer right, we won't need quite as much raw data, especially with India's strong solar energy potential.

This is the heart of the theory — the unifying lens that ties so many fragmented ideas together. I hope as you read further, you'll see the same patterns I do and feel empowered to apply them in your own life.

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1. Core Theory

We are going to observe the Earth from 3rd person point of view in our theory. We can view the Earth as a 3D space filled with matter.

An object is an identifiable collection of matter, which may be constrained by an identifiable boundary, and may move as a unit by translation or rotation, in 3-dimensional space. In the 3D space the boundaries of two objects may not overlap at any point in time.

We are classifying objects into 3 types for easier discussion - resource, data, agent. These terms are familiar for the reader so will be easier to explain future concepts.

Agents are some object which are making changes in the Earth. Agents can actively make decisions (eg humans) or influenced by other active agents (eg a human throwing a rock to hit another human, in this context that rock is acting as a passive agent).

Data is a special kind of object that supports 3 operations - storage, computation, and transfer.

Every data must be physically stored somewhere in the Earth. Based on existing data, agents can compute and produce new data. And data can be transferred to other storages. All active agents are making decisions based on the data stored in their database. A computation is happening, and they can transfer some data to other databases of other agents to affect how they act.

In an objective sense, we only care about the changes in the physical world, and to make changes in the physical world, agents have tools like hands and legs which can change the position of other matters.

Resource is an object that has some value in context of the survival of the agents.

Objects can't jump through space without traversing physically, hence movement speed is an essential parameter in the computations.

1.1 Evolution as our fundamental scientific theory

From an evolutionary standpoint, the primary goal of every living agent is to ensure their survival, and for that, they are trying to maintain a resource threshold Rmin sufficient for survival. For that, they are gathering new resources, improving existing resources, and protecting existing ones. More weightage is given towards protecting existing resources than gathering new ones, which is usually known as status quo bias.

Goal of having these resources in storage is to gain something in the future. The dilemma of exploration vs exploitation - explore more resources (that too takes resources without immediate usage) or exploit what you already have.

Resources are spent during decision making due to computation of data or when using tools like hands and legs to make changes in the physical world. The agents want to save resources as much as possible so they want certainty before taking any action. They want trusted resources at cheap cost.

So for decision making, we have two very important factors - trust and cost. Trust gets more weightage than cost, as survival is more important. So agents want to save resources and want trusted resources, so they prefer abstractions as much as possible. Abstraction is like cached value, some agent computed something and verified the usefulness of that value, and we are using that to save doing the same computation again. Abstraction can be from others or can be discovered by ourselves, like saving our own habits for future usage. For the same reason, both positive and negative habits can persist over a long time (status quo bias), because we prefer trusting existing working patterns than taking risks to figure out new habits, and those habits are encoded in the neurons so hard to ignore.

When using these abstractions, we are using binary thinking. During System 1 thinking, we only care about whether that abstraction is useful or non-useful for us. At that moment, we don't try to validate that. When we are trying to validate that, we call that self-reflection, but that takes System 2 thinking.

Now, agents want certainty. For that, hope is very important, and we don't want to waste computation on chasing something we can't get. When we are unsure about potential resource loss in the future from outside attacks, that makes us uncertain and anxious. When we are uncertain about our survival, we only focus on immediate goals because if we are not surviving in the long term, then why save the resources for future? It makes us too defensive; we only spend everything on defense. That means we are not accumulating new resources and losing what we already have, but we can't go beyond that shell, and that starts the negative spiral. Defences are net negative in general in an ideal world without competition and better to reduce as much as possble.

Now, evolutionarily speaking, our minds have trained to focus on scarce resources, and what is abundant we ignore because we know we can get that anytime. So it is impossible to stay satisfied with what we have, and that leads to the arms race. Everyone is focusing on what is scarce, and that leads to the competition.

For this competition, vying for resources leads to conflicts, and emotions are the indicator to tell us whether we are winning or losing the conflict over gaining that resource. If we are winning, you get positive emotions; if we are losing, we get negative emotions.

2. Group Dynamics

Speaking generally, agents must spend resources to get new resources. So the dilemma in group settings is whether to give more resources to individuals, which empowers them and they can gather more resources and the whole group also get more resources collectively. But as they are getting more independent they need the group less, and they can leave the group, and the other group members losing what they are currently getting. So that is the dilemma: whether to give more power to individuals or not.

So in any groups (societies or organizations), the goal is to allocate minimal individual power to maximize aggregate resource gains, as resources required for empowered agents to generate resources, while maintaining as much certainty as possible.

In any communication conflict arises, and we can gain leverage in only two forms - withdrawal of resources, like denying access to some resources that others are dependent on, or attack to directly seize resources from others.

Communication is about transferring data to other storages, and based on that, they are making decisions. Send data to others and make sure others trust that data so that they use it in their computation.

Everyone is trying to minimize resource spending. There are incentives to fake competence so that others help them by giving them resources. So we prefer costly signals for trusting others.

When everyone is getting powerful, it is hard to outright gain victory over others, so that leads to limited wars. That is uncertain because others are still present as a potential threat, but as we spoke about more collective gains, it is inevitable in an established society.

Earlier kings retained all the powers, and eventually that power is distributed among the masses. But still, most people are not original thinkers; they are followers of the leader class. Now as a next evolution that is going to change, and if everyone can think for themselves and confidently take decisions on their own, they are becoming more independent, and that leads to more innovation across the society, but also more individualism. That leads to the importance of diplomacy skills among the masses because otherwise, it will be impossible to cooperate and build something meaningful, and they would waste all the resources in conflicts.

3. Side Effects And Observations

Ideas like “truth” are not objective, and it is stored in the database of the majority of the agents in a certain culture, which feels like an objective fact, but it is just an observed phenomenon. Same with the “personality” of an agent that is not permanent, but just we want certainty about what kind of resources we can get from someone, and we assign a personality like introvert or extrovert to someone to expect what you can get from that.

But these concepts are in an unstructured environment. So it is hard to convert to formal language like computer programming for automation. It’s hard to articulate it. So it’s hard to delegate.

There is no constant state as happiness. Happiness comes from constant struggles because life has no inherent meaning. We are just trying to survive and by maintaining the resource threshold, and so the only hope is to stay in flow as much as possible. Staying just beyond your current ability but not too much ahead.

Adopt a minimalist doctrine, depend on as little as possible so that you don't feel anxious, while making progress.

4. Antifragile Strategy To Recover From Any Setback

When we are setting some setback, you can follow a four-stage procedure.

First, adopt an elastic defense, absorb and hold the pressure.

When you are stabilizing the frontline, you can organize and rebuild by finding supplies.

Once your supplies are secured, you can counter-attack and get back to the status quo before the conflict started.

Once this is done, you can decide whether to advance or consolidate your gains based on your grand strategy.

5. Decision Making Process For Agents

It goes through the following loop

1. (Planning horizon) Resource abundance compared to Rmin? Trust on available resources (both self and others) getting more if needed?

   Planning for how long? Plan long only if I will survive long, else why waste resource on something that I will never live to utilize? Employ system 1 or system 2 thinking?

2. (Recon) Available actions to take next? Which resources needs to be defended? Which resources can we target? Explore or exploit?

3. (System 1 estimation) How much resources is needed to take the next action? Means gathering, improving, or protecting the resource in consideration.

4. (Confidence and emotions) How much probability do we have of the success of that action? This leads to emotions in anticipation of resources.

Past data matters, whether we won or lost last time. Or borrow data (resource) from someone else with good trust (an abstraction).

Planning horizon determines patience in conficts and emotions.

5. (Procrastinate or not) Is it worth taking the action? Habit stays, loss aversion, status quo bias. When certainty of keeping current resources > certainty of getting new better resources.

   Depends on trust on the data. Else keep searching for new options, endless research. Procrastination.

   Is this rejected permanently or delaying?

6. (Escalation ladder) How much force to apply? If confidence in handling pushback, escalate quickly and wrap quickly. Else hedge or hesitate, leading to procrastination.

7. Either an action is choosen among the alternatives, or maintains status quo.

   If the action is taken conflict starts, are we winning or losing? But past doesn't matter except the data for evaluation.

   Brain is concerned about what will happen in future. Emotions are indicator. If negative emotions, give up else do more of it. Leading to habits in long run, easier to do as subconscious takes over. Updates Rmin and Rcurrent. Goes back to step 1.